Educational Equity and the Local Control Funding Formula: Analysis of California's Urban Policy Framework (2024–2026)

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The landscape of urban education in California has undergone a fundamental transformation since the 2013 enactment of the Local Control Funding Formula (LCFF), a policy shift that replaced a decades-old revenue limit and categorical funding system with a flexible, equity-based model.[2, 3] As the state enters the mid-2020s, the educational system faces a convergence of fiscal volatility, shifting demographic trends, and an urgent need to refine accountability mechanisms to ensure that targeted resources translate into measurable student success. This report analyzes the current urban educational policy environment, evaluating the mechanics of the LCFF, the fiscal pressures of the 2025–2026 budget cycle, and the efficacy of site-level interventions like the Equity Multiplier and the Community Schools model.

The Legislative and Philosophical Foundations of School Finance Reform

The Local Control Funding Formula grew out of criticism that the prior school finance system was complicated and overly prescriptive. Before the LCFF, the state funded schools through revenue limits and a large number of categorical programs, each with its own spending rules. The California School Boards Association (CSBA) describes the state as having funded schools "in an overly prescriptive manner through categorical programs coming from Sacramento," and notes that California ranked 46th in education spending in 2010.[2]

Legislatively, the formula was established through Assembly Bill 97, the 2013 budget trailer bill that replaced the existing revenue limit and categorical funding structure with the LCFF, and Senate Bill 91, which made technical clean-up changes to AB 97.[3, 4] Together they decentralized spending decisions to local districts while directing additional funding to students who are low-income, English learners, or foster youth.[2]

Weighted student funding also has a research literature behind it. Helen Ladd and Edward Fiske, for example, examined the Netherlands' weighted funding system as a possible model for the United States, and concluded that district-level weighting in the United States is unlikely to produce results as progressive as the Dutch system's.[5] The LCFF is a weighted student funding formula: it assumes that educating a student with language barriers or socioeconomic disadvantage costs more than educating a student without those challenges.[2] By consolidating categorical grants into a single formula, the state aimed to let local districts align spending with their own student populations, a process formalized through the Local Control and Accountability Plan (LCAP).[6]

Mechanics of the Local Control Funding Formula

The architecture of the LCFF is built upon three primary pillars: base grants, supplemental grants, and concentration grants. The base grant provides a uniform level of funding per unit of Average Daily Attendance (ADA), with adjustments made for different grade spans to reflect varying instructional costs.[6] For 2025–26, the adjusted base grant per ADA is $11,323 for grades TK–3, $10,411 for grades 4–6, $10,719 for grades 7–8, and $12,746 for grades 9–12.[9]

Beyond the base, the formula provides a 20% "supplemental" add-on for each unduplicated pupil (low-income, English learner, or foster youth). For districts where these high-need students exceed 55% of total enrollment, an additional "concentration" grant is provided for each high-need student above that threshold, to address the challenges of concentrated poverty. The concentration add-on was raised from 50% to 65% of the base grant beginning in 2022–23.[2, 9]

Table 1: LCFF Funding Components and Targeted Ratios (2024–2026)

Grant Component	Percentage Add-on to Base	Eligibility Criteria	Strategic Objective
Base Grant	100% (Baseline)	All students per ADA	Core instructional and operational costs
Supplemental Grant	20%	Unduplicated pupil count (Low-income, EL, Foster)	Targeted services for high-need students
Concentration Grant	65% (50% before 2022–23)	Unduplicated pupils above 55% threshold	Combatting the effects of concentrated poverty

Grant Component	Percentage Add-on to Base	Eligibility Criteria	Strategic Objective
Equity Multiplier	Site-specific rate	Nonstability > 25% and SED > 70%	Site-level stability and achievement gaps
TK Add-on	$5,545 per TK ADA (2025–26)	Transitional Kindergarten enrollment	Early childhood school readiness

Sources: 2, 8, 9

This tiered structure ensures that the highest-need districts receive significantly more per-pupil funding than their more affluent counterparts. However, the reliance on Average Daily Attendance as the primary unit of measurement has become a point of significant policy friction. While ADA provides a fiscal incentive for schools to ensure students are present, it also creates budget instability for urban districts where chronic absenteeism is more prevalent.[10]

Fiscal Landscape and Budgetary Projections (2025–2026)

The 2025–26 state budget changed between the Governor's January 2025 proposal and the budget the Legislature enacted in June 2025.[13, 15] This section uses the enacted figures and shows in Table 2 where they differ from the January proposal. CSBA described the theme of the January proposal as "caution and vigilance."[16] The administration placed its education priorities under the "California for All Kids" plan, which it describes as its TK–12 whole child framework.[15]

The Proposition 98 minimum guarantee, which sets the floor for K–14 education funding, is $114.6 billion for 2025–26 in the enacted budget, down from the $118.9 billion in the January proposal. The 2024–25 guarantee is $119.9 billion.[12] Total TK–12 funding for 2025–26 is $137.6 billion, and Proposition 98 funding for TK–12 works out to $18,534 per pupil.[12, 13]

The statutory cost-of-living adjustment (COLA) for the LCFF is 2.30% for 2025–26, below the 2.43% in the January proposal. The LAO prices the enacted COLA at $1.75 billion.[12, 14, 15] The Department of Finance reports that baseline adjustments and population growth increase discretionary funds for local educational agencies (LEAs) by $2.1 billion over the 2024 Budget Act; the January proposal had estimated about $2.5 billion.[12, 15] CSBA noted that districts and county offices of education are "pushing against financial headwinds."[16]

Table 2: Comparative Fiscal Outlook for K–12 Education, 2025–26: Governor's Proposal vs. Enacted Budget

Metric	Governor's proposal (January 2025)	Enacted budget (June 2025)
Prop 98 guarantee, 2024–25	$119.2 billion	$119.9 billion
Prop 98 guarantee, 2025–26	$118.9 billion	$114.6 billion
Total TK–12 funding, 2025–26	$137.1 billion	$137.6 billion
Prop 98 funding per pupil, 2025–26	$18,918	$18,534
LCFF COLA, 2025–26	2.43%	2.30%
LCFF deferral, June 2026 to July 2026	Not included	$1.9 billion
Prop 98 Rainy Day Fund	$1.5 billion ending balance, 2025–26	$455 million withdrawal in 2025–26 exhausts the balance

Sources: January proposal: 15. Enacted budget: 12, 13.

A significant maneuver in the enacted 2025–26 budget is the $1.9 billion deferral of LCFF apportionments from June 2026 to July 2026, which moves a month of 2025–26 payments into the next fiscal year.[12, 13, 14] The January proposal did not include this deferral.[15] The enacted budget also draws on the Proposition 98 Rainy Day Fund. The 2024–25 mandatory deposit was reduced from $540 million to $455 million, and a mandatory withdrawal of $455 million in 2025–26 exhausts the remaining balance.[12]

The 2026–27 budget, enacted in June 2026, changes this picture. It sets the Proposition 98 guarantee at $128.1 billion for 2026–27 and revises the 2025–26 guarantee up to $125.3 billion, compared with $114.6 billion when the 2025–26 budget was enacted, although it maintains a $3.9 billion settle-up obligation for 2025–26. Total TK–12 funding for 2026–27 is $151.4 billion.[17] The LCFF receives a 2.87% statutory COLA, and the budget adds a $1.1 billion "super COLA" that brings the total COLA to 4.31%. The Department of Finance says the added funds are meant to help districts manage rising costs, offset funding reductions from declining enrollment, and cover a new paid pregnancy disability leave

requirement.[17] The LAO lists $1.9 billion in one-time Proposition 98 funds to pay down the LCFF deferral.[18] The Proposition 98 Rainy Day Fund is projected at $9.2 billion, which triggers reserve caps for school districts beginning in 2026–27.[17] The Department of Finance's TK–12 summary does not describe any change to the attendance-based student count discussed in the next section.[17]

The Attendance Crisis: Analyzing the ADA vs. Enrollment Paradigm

Perhaps the most significant structural debate in contemporary California school finance is the proposed shift from an ADA-based student count to one based on enrollment. Under current law, districts are funded based on the average number of students attending school each day throughout the year. Post-pandemic, however, attendance rates fell from a pre-pandemic average of 95.7% to a low of 90.6% in 2021–22.[10] Although rates are slowly rebounding, they remain about 2 percentage points below 2019 levels, leading to funding losses for urban districts where absenteeism is concentrated.[10]

The LAO estimates that shifting to an enrollment-based methodology would increase state costs by over $6 billion annually. Using enrollment for the LCFF would increase costs by about $5.7 billion, and shifting other ongoing programs would add almost $800 million.[10] Proponents of this shift argue that enrollment-based funding better reflects the fixed costs of running a school, such as teacher salaries and facility maintenance, which do not decrease when a student is absent.[10]

Table 3: Fiscal and Policy Trade-offs of Funding Methodologies

Criteria	ADA-Based (Status Quo)	Enrollment-Based (Proposed)
State Cost	Baseline	Over $6 billion more annually ($5.7 billion for the LCFF alone)
Equity Impact	Benefits high-attendance/affluent districts	Benefits high-need/urban districts
Fiscal Incentive	Encourages attendance promotion	May reduce incentive for outreach
Budget Planning	Volatile/Hard to predict	Stable/Aligned with staffing

Criteria	ADA-Based (Status Quo)	Enrollment-Based (Proposed)
Historical Trend	Statewide attendance rose after the late-1990s shift to attendance-based funding	Removes the fiscal incentive to improve attendance

Source: 10

The trade-offs are stark. While an enrollment-based system would provide more resources to high-need districts (which currently have lower attendance rates on average), the LAO cautions that it would remove the primary fiscal incentive for districts to prioritize attendance.[10] Statewide attendance rose after the state adopted its current attendance-based funding in the late 1990s, and the LAO concludes that the policy likely was a factor, although it cannot measure the specific impact. That suggests the fiscal incentive may be effective.[10] However, the Public Policy Institute of California (PPIC) suggests that the state's current "declining enrollment" trend might offer a window of opportunity: as the total number of students falls, the state could potentially transition to enrollment-based funding without reducing the absolute funding of any district, leveraging the resulting "fiscal slack" to cover the cost.[21]

Granular Equity: The LCFF Equity Multiplier and Concentrated Need

Recognizing that the broad district-level concentration grants often fail to reach the most volatile school sites, California introduced the LCFF Equity Multiplier in the 2023–24 budget. This site-specific funding mechanism allocates $300 million annually to schools with a prior-year "nonstability" rate greater than 25% and a socioeconomically disadvantaged (SED) rate greater than 70%.[8] By using the nonstability rate as an eligibility criterion, the Equity Multiplier treats student mobility, or "churn," as a barrier to academic progress that poverty measures alone may not capture.

Equity Multiplier funds are strictly "supplement, not supplant," meaning they must be used to provide new or enhanced evidence-based services.[8] For the 2025–26 cycle, districts are required to document these efforts in their LCAP through specific "focus goals" for every eligible school site.[8] These goals must address student groups performing at the lowest level (Red) on the California School Dashboard and must also investigate "underlying issues in the credentialing, subject matter preparation, and retention" of the school's educators.[8]

Case Study Insight: Stockton Unified and Natomas Unified

In the Stockton Unified School District (SUSD), the 2025–26 Equity Multiplier plan targets schools like El Dorado Elementary and Jane Frederick High. SUSD's strategy emphasizes Professional Learning Communities (PLCs) and instructional coaching, specifically focusing on English Language Arts (ELA) and Math.[23] Success is measured not just by Smarter Balanced test scores, but by a 10% reduction in chronic absenteeism and a 15% increase in positive responses on annual climate surveys.[23]

Similarly, Natomas Unified has utilized these funds to implement restorative justice training and hire "Teachers on Special Assignment" (TOSAs) to lead intensive interventions in grades 3 through 8.[24] These roles are tasked with analyzing data from the I-Ready platform to equip classroom teachers with resources for Tier II interventions like Read 180 and Math 180.[24] This illustrates a move toward "data-driven equity," where funding is tethered to specific instructional shifts rather than general operating expenses.

The Whole-Child Paradigm: California Community Schools Partnership Program

The most ambitious expansion of the urban educational framework in recent years is the California Community Schools Partnership Program (CCSPP). The Legislature allocated a historic $4.1 billion to the program in 2021 and 2022.[25] The CCSPP seeks to transform schools into "villages of support" that integrate academics, health, and social services.[26]

A 2025 impact study by the Learning Policy Institute (LPI) examined the first cohort of CCSPP-funded schools, 458 grantee schools, and compared them with similar schools. It found positive impacts after 2023–24, the first full year of implementation.[27, 29] Grantee schools saw about a 30% greater reduction in chronic absence than matched comparison schools.[27] For Black students, the impact was particularly large, equating to approximately 130 extra days of learning in math and 151 days in ELA.[27]

Table 4: Student Outcomes in CCSPP Implementation Schools

Metric	Estimated effect on grantee schools, relative to matched comparison schools	Where effects were largest, or what they equal
Chronic absence rate	About 30% greater reduction	Strongest gains in elementary and small schools
Suspension rate	About 15% reduction on average	Largest decreases for Black students and secondary schools
Math performance	+0.06 standard deviations	About 43 additional learning days
ELA performance	+0.05 standard deviations	About 36 additional learning days
English learners	58 additional days of learning in math; 72 in ELA	Compare with averages of 43 (math) and 36 (ELA) days

Sources: 27, 30

Community schools are organized around four pillars: integrated student supports, expanded learning time, active family and community engagement, and collaborative leadership.[30] The LPI study noted that the strongest academic improvements occurred in schools that made the most progress in reducing chronic absence. That is consistent with a pathway in which improved attendance, driven by "whole-child" strategies, allows students to benefit more from instruction.[29]

Schools report local results as well. Wheatland Union High, which serves about 1,100 students, reports that its graduation rate rose from 78.6% to 100% in one year after it began implementing the CCSPP, and that chronic absenteeism fell 25%. Its community school work includes career technical education pathways and restorative practices.[31] The source does not give the school years or a data source for these figures, so they illustrate what a district reports rather than evidence of the CCSPP's effect.

Early Childhood and Literacy Initiatives

The 2025–26 school year is an important milestone in the "California for All Kids" plan: transitional kindergarten (TK) is open to all children who turn four by September 1.[15] In the enacted budget, $2.1 billion in ongoing Proposition 98 funding, including prior years' investments, supports TK access for roughly 51,000 additional children over 2024–25.

Another $1.2 billion in ongoing funding lowers the student-to-adult ratio in every TK classroom from 12:1 to 10:1.[12] The January proposal had estimated $2.4 billion and about 60,000 children for TK expansion, and $1.5 billion for the ratio change.[15]

Beyond access, the budget focuses on the quality of early instruction. The enacted budget provides $40 million in one-time funding for literacy screening in kindergarten through second grade and $215 million in one-time funding to expand the Literacy Coaches and Reading Specialists Grant Program, along with $30 million for a Mathematics Professional Learning Partnership.[12] The January proposal had listed $500 million in one-time funding for TK–12 Literacy and Mathematics Coaches.[15] These investments rest on the premise that early intervention costs less than remediation in later grades. The enacted budget also lowers the unduplicated pupil percentage (UPP) threshold for universal access to expanded learning programs from 75% to 55% and provides $515.1 million in ongoing funding for the program, which broadens the "equity net" for expanded learning opportunities.[12]

Disciplinary Paradigms: Restorative Justice vs. Informal Exclusion

Urban education policy has shifted away from "zero-tolerance" punitive measures toward Restorative Justice (RJ). RJ practices focus on repairing harm through dialogue and mediation, rather than suspension or expulsion.[32] The San Mateo-Foster City School District reports that middle school discipline incidents declined between 2019–20 and 2024–25 in categories such as fighting, intimidation, and drug-related offenses. It also reports that in the 2024 California Healthy Kids Survey, 70% of middle school students said they feel close to people at their school, up from 53% in previous years, which the district describes as a "remarkable increase" in connectedness.[34]

However, a 2025 Stanford study raises a warning about "informal exclusionary discipline practices."[35] The qualitative study drew on interviews with 63 parents, teachers, administrators, and behavior specialists in early childhood settings in San Francisco Unified. Its authors warn that formal discipline bans alone are not enough. They recommend adequate staffing for non-punitive alternatives, sustained training for educators, and mandatory tracking of informal practices. Without those supports, teachers may resort to "sending a student into the hallway unsupervised or home from school early."[35] Because these exclusions are not documented, they may disproportionately affect racially, ethnically, and economically marginalized students without any procedural oversight.[35]

Restorative and Related Discipline Practices: Intent and Potential Unintended Consequences

Discipline Practice	Intent	Potential Unintended Consequence
Restorative Circles	Build community and repair harm	Lack of staff time and investment can undermine intent
Suspension Bans	Keep students in class/learning	May trigger informal "hallway" exclusions
Peace Rooms and calm-down corners	Provide de-escalation and wellness support	Can become informal exclusion when used to remove students from class

Sources: 32, 35

The success of restorative justice is therefore highly contingent on institutional capacity. A 2025 University of California, Riverside student research paper on Coachella Valley Unified found that stronger RJ implementation was associated with lower suspension rates, although the model explained little of the variation.[32] Its literature review favors whole-school approaches over standalone tools and warns that under-resourced rollouts can be misaligned with restorative principles.[32]

Critical Evaluation of Performance-Based Funding (PBF)

While the LCFF is an input-based weighted formula, there is a recurring interest in Performance-Based Funding (PBF), linking state appropriations to student outcomes like graduation or test score growth.[36] Proponents argue that PBF creates an incentive for efficiency and rewards schools that succeed with at-risk populations.[36]

A systematic review of 36 articles on PBF in higher education, however, found that such policies are generally "not effective" in improving completion or equity.[38] Research on higher education also points to unintended consequences, including restricted access for underserved students as institutions become more selective to improve their performance metrics.[37] By extension, K–12 PBF could embed existing inequities: already under-resourced schools serving high-poverty urban areas might receive even fewer resources if they fail to meet standardized benchmarks. Critics argue that the state

should prioritize "fair school funding," meaning sufficient baseline levels and progressive distribution, rather than "inputs vs. outputs" maneuvers that may penalize the most vulnerable.[40]

Demographic Transitions and the "Fiscal Slack" Opportunity

California's K–12 system is entering a period of "downsizing and adjustment."[11] The Department of Finance projects that enrollment will fall below 5.2 million by 2032, and the National Center for Education Statistics projects a decline to just under 5 million by 2031. Greater Los Angeles enrollment fell about 15% over the past decade, and PPIC reports a projected 19% loss between 2022–23 and 2032–33.[11] While this forces districts to make difficult decisions regarding school closures and staffing, it also creates a unique fiscal dynamic under Proposition 98.

Because the total funding guarantee is tied to the state's economy and General Fund rather than just enrollment, a smaller base of students can result in higher per-pupil funding, provided the state budget grows at about the rate of inflation.[11] PPIC estimates that if per-student funding keeps growing at the same rate as overall education funding, the Proposition 98 guarantee would exceed that spending by about $7.5 billion in 2030, or roughly $1,500 per student.[21] The projection assumes enrollment falls to about 5.47 million in 2030–31 and the guarantee grows about 2.7% a year in real terms. If growth in per-student funding were capped at 2%, the amount would be $11.5 billion.[21] This "fiscal slack" is the key to the political feasibility of future LCFF reforms. It could allow the state to implement changes like enrollment-based funding or regional cost adjustments (which cost billions) without the political "losers" that typically accompany a zero-sum redistribution of funds.[21] The slack is a projection for 2030, not money available now. In the meantime, the 2026–27 budget's "super COLA" is intended to help offset funding reductions from declining enrollment.[17]

Table 5: Proposed LCFF Modifications and Estimated Costs

Proposed Reform	Estimated additional state cost	Primary Objective
Enrollment-Based Funding	$3.8 billion (PPIC) to $5.7 billion (LAO), LCFF only	Stabilization for chronic absenteeism losses
Regional Cost Adjustment	$2.5 billion	Accounting for competitive teacher wages

Proposed Reform	Estimated additional state cost	Primary Objective
Dual-Need Funding	About $1.7 billion	Targeted funds for students with multiple needs
Smoothing Cutoffs	About $1.5 billion	Eliminating the 55% "concentration cliff"

Sources: PPIC [21] for all rows; LAO [10] for the upper enrollment-based estimate. The LAO figure covers the LCFF only; its estimate for all affected programs is over $6 billion. PPIC's enrollment-based estimate excludes charter schools and county offices of education. PPIC does not state a budget year for its estimates, and its key takeaways round the dual-need cost to roughly $2 billion, while the report body gives about $1.7 billion.

Stakeholder Influence and Policy Adoption Dynamics

The political feasibility of urban policy alternatives in California is dictated by the interaction of major stakeholders. School districts, represented by bodies like the California School Boards Association (CSBA), prioritize "discretionary funding" and the "flexibility" to make decisions at the local level to address their unique populations. CSBA has objected that the state "captures discretionary one-time Prop 98 dollars and allocates them as categorical funding."[16]

Teachers' organizations, such as the CTA, have campaigned for smaller class sizes and "mental health support and other resources for students."[43] Meanwhile, parent and community organizations, such as the Education Trust-West, focus on "transparency" and "accountability," arguing that concentration funds must directly benefit the high-need students who generated them.[44] PPIC testimony indicates that concentration districts (those receiving the largest shares of equity funding) often "target less" at the school site level, spreading dollars equally across all schools rather than focusing on the highest-need sites.[45] This "targeting gap" remains a primary point of contention in the LCAP reform debate.

Synthesis and Strategic Recommendations

The analysis of California's urban education policy for the 2024–2026 cycle reveals a system that is functionally progressive but mechanically strained. The LCFF has directed billions of dollars toward high-need populations, but post-pandemic attendance shifts

and looming enrollment declines necessitate a strategic pivot. To strengthen the equity framework and improve urban educational outcomes, the following recommendations are proposed:

1. **Modernize the Student Count Methodology.** The state should transition from ADA-based to enrollment-based funding. PPIC projects fiscal slack of about $7.5 billion by 2030 from declining enrollment. That could cover the estimated cost of this switch, $3.8 billion to $5.7 billion for the LCFF alone (over $6 billion if other programs also shift), without reducing funding for high-attendance districts.[10, 21] This would provide fiscal stability for urban centers where chronic absenteeism currently penalizes school budgets.
2. **Refine the Equity Formula for "Dual Needs."** The LCFF should be amended to provide additional funding for students who fall into multiple targeted categories (e.g., a student who is both an English learner and low-income). This "duplicated targeted funding" would direct an estimated $1.7 billion toward the districts serving the most vulnerable, multi-burdened populations.[21]
3. **Institutionalize the Community School Model.** Given the 30% greater reduction in chronic absence and significant learning gains for Black students in CCSPP schools, the state should transition these implementation grants into ongoing, formulaic funding.[27] This ensures that the "whole-child" supports are not lost once one-time grants expire. The 2026–27 budget includes $1 billion in ongoing Proposition 98 funding to expand the model.[17]
4. **Strengthen Site-Level Workforce Stability.** The Equity Multiplier's focus on teacher retention and credentialing should be expanded.[8] The state should incentivize "Educator Diversity and Retention" grants specifically for Equity Multiplier sites, because instructional quality is central to the math and ELA outcomes these sites are working to improve.
5. **Enforce Reciprocal Accountability.** LCAPs should be reformed from "bureaucratic compliance" documents into "community engagement platforms."[46] This includes creating "trigger laws" that enforce state fiscal obligations to districts and requiring districts to provide clearer, school-level spending data to ensure that supplemental funds are reaching the students for whom they were intended.[45]

California's LCFF is an important example of equity-based school finance, but its next decade requires a more nuanced, site-specific focus. By addressing the attendance crisis, targeting dual-need students, and stabilizing the urban educator workforce, the state can ensure that its historic investments result in the "acceleration" of learning for all students, regardless of their zip code or socioeconomic background.

Sources

Sources opened or re-checked for the October 2026 update show an access date of October 27, 2026. Sources carried over from the original paper and not re-opened keep their original access date of April 19, 2026. Entries 1, 7, 19, 20, 22, 28, 33, 39, 41, 42, and 47 are listed for background and are not cited in the text.

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